

HOW TO USE MODAL VERBS

1. Modals of Advice (建议)

We use modals of advice to give suggestions, recommendations, or warnings.

Form: modal + verb (base form)

should / shouldn't · 应该 / 不应该 (日常建议)

- You **should check** the metro schedule before leaving. (离开前你应该查一下地铁时刻表。)
- We **shouldn't order** takeout every night — cooking is healthier. (我们不该天天点外卖，自己做更健康。)
- You **should bring** an umbrella — the forecast says rain. (你应该带把伞，天气预报说有雨。)

had better / had better not · 最好 / 最好别 (强语气建议，含后果警示)

- You **had better submit** the report before 5 pm today. (你最好在今天下午五点前提交报告。)
- We **had better leave** now, or we will get stuck in traffic. (我们最好现在出发，否则会堵在路上。)
- She **had better not be** late — the team lead is upset. (她最好别迟到了，组长已经很不高兴了。)

ought to · 应当 / 应该 (常理、道义或规范建议)

- A new tenant **ought to check** the plumbing before moving in. (新租客入住前应当检查下水管道。)
- He **ought to start** jogging — his blood pressure is high. (他应当开始慢跑，他的血压偏高。)
- Every employee **ought to back up** important project files. (每位员工都应当备份重要项目文件。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What should a job applicant prepare before an online interview?
- What had an employee better not say during a performance review?
- How much money should a young worker save from their monthly salary?
- What ought a newcomer to do if they get lost in a large subway station?

2. Modals of Necessity (必要与义务)

Modals of necessity express obligations, mandatory rules, or absence of obligation.

Form: modal + verb (base form)

must / must not · 必须 / 严禁 (刚性规定与禁止)

- Passengers **must scan** their QR code before boarding the train. (乘客上车前必须出示扫码。)
- Delivery riders **must wear** helmets while riding on city streets. (外卖骑手骑行时必须佩戴头盔。)
- You **must not smoke** anywhere inside this office building. (办公楼内任何区域都严禁吸烟。)

have to / don't have to · 不得不 / 不必 (客观需要与免除义务)

- I **have to renew** my apartment lease before the end of this month. (我必须在月底前续签租房合同。)
- He **has to work** overtime tomorrow even though it is Saturday. (虽然明天是周六，但他不得不加班。)
- You **don't have to come** to the office on remote work days. (居家办公日你不需要来办公室。)

have got to · 得 / 必须 (口语强调)

- We **have got to buy** a new rice cooker — ours is broken. (我们真得买个新电饭煲了，旧的坏了。)
- I **have got to finish** these slides before the 2 pm meeting. (我得在下午两点开会前把这几页 PPT 做完。)
- You **have got to try** this new coffee shop near the station. (你真得试试车站旁这家新开的咖啡店。)

had to · 当时不得不 (过去必要)

- She **had to take** a taxi because the bus was delayed. (因为公交车晚了，她当时不得不打车。)
- We **had to cancel** the camping trip due to the heavy rain. (因为暴雨，我们当时不得不取消露营计划。)
- He **had to stay** at the office until midnight to fix the server. (为了修服务器，他昨晚不得不待到半夜。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What daily tasks do you have to finish before clocking out?
- What safety rules must passengers follow on high-speed trains?
- Why do office workers have to check messaging apps during the day?
- What documents do you have to prepare when renting an apartment?

3. Modals of Possibility and Probability (推测与把握程度)

We use modal verbs to make logical deductions and express how certain we are based on evidence.

Form: modal + verb (base form)

must · 一定 / 肯定 (95% 把握的肯定推测)

- The café is packed — their new seasonal drink **must be** good. (咖啡馆挤满了人，他们的新品一定很好喝。)
- The lights are still on — he **must be** working on the proposal. (灯还亮着，他肯定还在加班赶方案。)
- You've been in meetings all day — you **must be** exhausted. (你开了一整天会，现在一定累坏了。)

may / could · 也许 / 可能 (50%–60% 把握的中等推测)

- It **may rain** this afternoon — look at those dark clouds. (下午可能会下雨，看天上的乌云。)
- If you leave right now, you **could catch** the 6:15 train. (如果你现在出发，也许能赶上 6 点 15 分的班次。)
- We **may receive** the bonus announcement by next Friday. (我们可能在下周五前收到发奖金的通知。)

might / might not · 或许 / 可能不 (30%–40% 把握的低确定推测)

- He **might be** stuck on subway Line 10 during rush hour. (早高峰他或许正堵在地铁 10 号线上。)
- The room is empty — the team **might be** having lunch outside. (会议室是空的，团队或许出去吃午饭了。)
- The food delivery **might not arrive** on time in this storm. (雨这么大，外卖可能无法按时送达。)

can't · 不可能 (95% 把握的否定推测)

- That **can't be** Li Wei at the desk — he is in Shenzhen today. (前台不可能是李伟，他今天在深圳出差。)
- This electric car **can't be** out of power — I charged it today. (这辆电车不可能没电，我今天刚充满。)
- It **can't be** 7 pm already — my watch says only 5:30. (不可能已经晚上七点了，我表上才五点半。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- If a milk tea shop has a long line, what must customers think?
- Why might it be hard to hail a ride on a rainy Friday evening?
- If a coworker looks totally exhausted, what could have happened?
- What AI tools or smart devices might change office work soon?

4. Modals of Past Regret · 本来..... (表达后悔与遗憾)

We use modal + have + past participle to talk about past actions that didn't happen as wished, expressing regret or criticism.

Form: should have / could have / shouldn't have + past participle

should have done · 本该做..... (遗憾没做)

- I **should have set** two alarms — I woke up 30 minutes late. (我本该设两个闹钟的，今天起晚了半小时。)
- We **should have booked** the train earlier — tickets are sold out. (我们本该早点订高铁票的，现在票卖光了。)
- He **should have backed up** his files before updating the OS. (他本该在更新系统前备份文件的。)

shouldn't have done · 本不该做..... (后悔做了)

- I **shouldn't have eaten** that spicy hot pot — my stomach hurts. (我真不该吃那么辣的火锅，胃好难受。)
- We **shouldn't have waited** until Friday to start this slide deck. (我们本不该拖到周五才开始做这份 PPT。)
- She **shouldn't have replied** to that angry email late at night. (她真不该在深夜回复那封带情绪的邮件。)

could have done · 本来可以..... (本有能力或机会做，但未做)

- I **could have taken** the direct subway, but I took the slow bus. (我本来可以坐地铁直达的，却坐了慢车。)
- We **could have negotiated** lower rent with a two-year lease. (如果我们签两年租约，本来可以谈下更低房租。)
- You **could have asked** a coworker for help instead of staying late. (你本来可以找同事帮忙的，而不必加班到深夜。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What is something you should have done differently on your last trip?
- What is a recent purchase you feel you shouldn't have bought?
- What routine task at work could you have handled more efficiently?
- What makes you think, "I should have left home ten minutes earlier"?